

Review article: Numerical Methods for Engineering Quantum Computers

Liu, Shu

Mathematics, Florida State University

Georgiadou, Antigoni

Oak Ridge National Laboratory

Dong, Spencer

Oak Ridge National Laboratory

Kubischta, Eric

Mathematics, Florida State University

Melton, Daniel

Mathematics, Florida State University

Guenther, Stefanie

Lawrence Livermore National Laboratory

Jin, Shi

Mathematics, Shanghai Jiao Tong University

Lin, Lin

Mathematics, U.C. Berkeley

Lotshaw, Philip

Oak Ridge National Laboratory

Petersson, Anders

Lawrence Livermore National Laboratory

Sussman, Mark

Mathematics, Florida State University

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ABSTRACT: In the article by Herrmann et al, “Quantum utility – definition and assessment of a practical quantum advantage,” the quantum computer “Application Readiness Level” (ARL) is defined: (ARL1) “concept with unknown potential,” (ARL2) “beneficial in small idealized systems,” (ARL3)

“utility indicated by theory or resource estimations,” (ARL4) “simulated utility demonstration,” and (ARL5) “utility demonstration on quantum hardware.” Hermann et al posit that ARL3 has been reached via demonstrations of the Variational Quantum Eigenvalue (VQE) algorithm. In this review article, the latest activities from the computational “digital twin” perspective are reported on in which scientists are working hard to bring practitioners out of the Noisy Intermediate Scale Quantum (NISQ) era into an era of “Quantum supremacy.” In other words this review article discusses digital twin activities that help to advance from ARL3 to ARL4, or even ARL5. The three main categories in this review article are (1) Optimization, Control, inverse problems, and exploratory simulation algorithms for Schrodinger’s equation, (2) Quantum computer Error correction, and (3) Quantum algorithms for benchmarking quantum computers (to include emulator algorithms like Qiskit).

1 Introduction

The motivation for this review article is the fact that Moore’s law is no longer applicable[90]. As quoted from Shalf[109], “Moore’s Law [1] is a techno-economic model that has enabled the IT industry to double the performance and functionality of digital electronics roughly every 2 years within a fixed cost, power and area. This expectation has led to a relatively stable ecosystem (e.g. electronic design automation tools, compilers, simulators and emulators) built around general-purpose processor technologies, such as the $\times 86$, ARM and Power instruction set architectures. However, within a decade, the technological underpinnings for the process that Gordon Moore described will come to an end, as lithography gets down to atomic scale. At that point, it will be feasible to create lithographically produced devices with dimensions nearing atomic scale, where a dozen or fewer silicon atoms are present across critical device features, and will therefore represent a practical limit for implementing logic gates for digital computing [2]. Indeed, the ITRS (International Technology Roadmap for Semiconductors), which has tracked the historical improvements over the past 30 years, has projected no improvements beyond 2021, as shown in figure 1, and subsequently disbanded, having no further purpose. The classical technological driver that has underpinned Moore’s Law for the past 50 years is failing [3] and is anticipated to flatten by 2025, as shown in figure 2. Evolving technology in the absence of Moore’s Law will require an investment now in computer architecture and the basic sciences (including materials science), to study candidate replacement materials and alternative device physics to foster continued technology scaling.”

References one through three in the above quote correspond to the following references respectively: [90][86][88].

As further motivation for this review article, in Figure 3 of the article by Shalf[109], a roadmap is provided for possible paths forward when the density of circuits on classical computers exceeds a critical value. There are three categories: (a) roadmap for the next ten years, (b) 20 years, and (c) “Decades

beyond exascale,” “New Models of Computation.” For category (c), Shalf[109] refers to the following prospective technology: (i) approximate computing, (ii) adiabatic reversible, (iii) Analog, (iv) Neuromorphic, and (v) quantum[32, 33]. Of the “new models of computation” listed in Shalf’s article[109], this review article will address the “Numerical Methods for Engineering Quantum Computers” aspects associated with the emerging “quantum computing” paradigm. As outlined by Gamble[35], the development of reliable quantum computers will have a transformative effect on computer technology. A perfectly working fifty qubit quantum computer can efficiently process 2^{50} pieces of data which is 1024 Terabytes (1 Petabyte)! That being said, right now we are in the “Noisy Intermediate-Scale Quantum”[18] (NISQ) era. The purpose of this review article is to bring to the forefront the current research being done, from the computational perspective, in order to move beyond the NISQ era.

2 Optimization, Control, inverse problems, and exploratory simulation algorithms for Schrodinger’s equation

In 1982, Feit et al[31] developed a spectral method for determining the eigenvalues and eigenfunctions of the time independent Schrodinger equation:

$$i\frac{\partial\psi}{\partial t} = -\frac{1}{2M}\nabla^2\psi + V(x,y)\psi \quad (1)$$

$$\psi(x,y,t) = \sum_{n,j} A_{nj}u_{nj}(x,y)e^{-iE_nt} \quad (2)$$

$$E_nu_{nj} = -\frac{1}{2M}\nabla^2u_{nj} + Vu_{nj}, \quad (3)$$

where

$$\nabla^2 = \frac{\partial^2}{\partial x^2} + \frac{\partial^2}{\partial y^2}. \quad (4)$$

In 2002, Bao et al[5] developed a time splitting spectral approximation for the time dependent Schrodinger equation in the “semiclassical” regime:

$$iu_t^\epsilon = -\frac{\epsilon}{2}\Delta u^\epsilon + \frac{1}{\epsilon}V(x)u^\epsilon \quad x \in R^d \quad u^\epsilon(x,0) = u_0^\epsilon(x) \quad (5)$$

Bao et al report results in one and two space dimensions.

In 2004, Zheng et al[127] developed a finite element method for finding the ground state of the lithium atom. In otherwords, Zheng et al found the smallest

eigenvalue and the associated eigenfunction for the time independent Schrodinger equation:

$$E\psi = H\psi \quad (6)$$

where the Hamiltonian operator H is defined as

$$H = -\frac{1}{2}(\Delta_1 + \Delta_2 + \Delta_3) - \frac{3}{r_1} - \frac{3}{r_2} - \frac{3}{r_3} + \frac{1}{r_{12}} + \frac{1}{r_{13}} + \frac{1}{r_{23}} \quad (7)$$

$$\Delta_j = \frac{\partial^2}{\partial x_j^2} + \frac{\partial^2}{\partial y_j^2} + \frac{\partial^2}{\partial z_j^2} \quad 1 \leq j \leq 3 \quad (8)$$

$$r_{jk} = |\vec{r}_j - \vec{r}_k| \quad r_j = |\vec{r}_j| \quad (9)$$

After converting from cartesian coordinate system to spherical coordinate system, the authors were able to reduce the dimension of the problem from 9 to 6.

In Grivopoulos' 2005 Phd thesis[39], methods were developed for the control of quantum systems. We highlight one such control problem discussed in the thesis. The Lindblad equation[87, 78] for open quantum systems is (see 3.7 in [39]):

$$\dot{\rho} = -i[H, \rho] + \sum_n K_n \rho K_n' - \frac{1}{2} \{ \sum_n K_n' K_n, \rho \} \quad (10)$$

The Lindblad equation models the interaction of two quantum systems, A and B, with respective Hilbert spaces H_A and H_B . The Hilbert space for the composite space is,

$$H_{AB} = H_A \otimes H_B \quad (11)$$

A general state vector on the composite space is,

$$\psi_{AB} = \psi_A \otimes \psi_B. \quad (12)$$

As stated in [39], "For the open system A (interacting with its environment B), ρ is the state variable analogous to the vector ψ for an isolated quantum system." Expressions for ρ are:

$$\rho = \text{tr}_B \psi_{AB} \psi_{AB}' = \sum_{ij} \left(\sum_I (\psi_{AB})_{iI}^* (\psi_{AB})_{jI} \right) e_j e_i' \quad (13)$$

Note that ρ is self-adjoint, positive semi-definite, and $\text{tr} \rho = 1$. As an example of control of open quantum systems, [39], considers a control problem for the laser cooling of atoms and molecules. The Lindblad equation with Hamiltonian control is

$$\dot{\rho} = -i[H_0 + Vu(t), \rho] + L(\rho), \quad (14)$$

where

$$L(\rho) = \sum_{ij} K_{ij} \rho K_{ij}^\dagger - \frac{1}{2} \{K_{ij}^\dagger K_{ij}, \rho\} \quad (15)$$

[39], for the 3×3 case, determines the control, $u(t)$, in (14), that maximizes $\rho_{11}(T)$ given $\rho(0) = \rho_0$.

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3 Quantum algorithms and Quantum emulators for benchmarking quantum computers

3.1 Quantum Emulators

The development of Quantum Emulators is essential for benchmarking quantum computers since (i) the level of noise in Quantum Emulators can be prescribed exactly thereby enabling practitioners to debug their quantum circuit and (ii) one can prescribe a given noise model[81] and then compare emulator results with an actual quantum computer in order to characterise the actual noise present in a quantum computer.

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